

spend beyond their means and then treat their kids like their retirement plan. (My mom has joked throughout my life about me being her retirement plan. Cool.)

The money that might go toward a child's college fund or even a good preschool will go toward Kitty and Piggy's own lives, careers, and retirement funds. It's dystopian to have a system that makes people choose between having a child and securing their own futures, but here we are.

"How are you supposed to pay off your student loans and save for retirement if you're also paying for your parents' retirement?" Piggy asked. Never mind adding in a new baby. This, most likely, will be my situation soon. This idea of forgoing having children to unburden the future is common among people my age.

In fact, according to a study by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the birthrate between 2007 and 2016 "fell by 338,000 [babies]." (Even something as adorable as babies seems terrifying when you picture 338,000 of them.) A Wharton School of Business study "found more than half (58%) of millennial female undergraduates do not plan to have children" and "even millennials who do want children say they do not see a clear path toward it."

New mom Anna Sale, the host of the podcast *Death, Sex & Money*, told me that as soon as she found out she was pregnant, she confirmed that her insurance covered prenatal care. It did. What she didn't know until it was too late was that it *did not* cover ultrasounds, blood work, anatomy scans, or anything else related to the pregnancy. Surprise! It's a . . . medical bill!

Indeed, babies are made up of little bills: prebirth tests and scans, a \$200 car seat, top-of-the-line breast pump equipment. The list is never-ending. Later in her pregnancy, Sale said that when the bills kept piling up, she had to start discerning whether certain tests and scans were mandatory so she could choose which were worth the cost.

There is also a ton of judgments online and IRL about what products you allow near your child. She says the various baby blogs essentially say, "If you want the really nice baby stuff, here's this list. If you want the kinda nice stuff, here's this list. And if you're on a superbudget and a bad parent, get the cheap